

Episode 13: Once Upon a Time... (9) Strip Colour Charts and Paint Maniacs

It's supposedly Golden Week (GW) in society. If you take the right days off, this year's GW could be 9 consecutive days - how are you all spending it? (laughs)

This year I'm basically working. Well, I'm always working regardless of the calendar anyway. But when the weather's nice, I naturally want to go somewhere. So if it would rain, I could give up easily... (← troubling for others).

While saying that, with the attitude of "I'm not going anywhere this GW, so I'll splurge instead!" I actually got a new digital camera. A compact model for "always carrying with me." Incidentally, this makes my digital camera collection the 9th one! Including film cameras, it's my 16th camera (explosion).

Once you get a new digital camera, it's natural to want to try it out (bitter laugh). ...I wonder if I'll go somewhere camera in hand during the latter half of the holidays?

Well then.

When it comes to essential items for colour direction in the paint era, it was definitely the strip colour chart.

In industries dealing with colour - publishing, printing, and others - they almost always use "colour samples," right? For example, when choosing wallpaper at home centres or even for paint, there are strip-shaped sample bundles at sales floors so you can compare colour differences up close. Similarly, cel paints had strip-shaped colour sample charts.

Had... or rather, in our case, we made them ourselves as needed. STAC did sell strip charts for their 120 basic colours (I think it was made-to-order), but it was about 5,000 yen per set. I don't know about **Taiyo Shikisai**, but since it cost 5,000 yen, naturally we made our own (laughs).

We'd paint cels and cut them to strips about 7cm tall by 2.5cm wide. This size was about the best. Bigger became unwieldy and hard to handle. Since there would be 200-300 pieces total, if each piece was large, the volume when bundled would be tremendous. Carrying them would be tough too.

First, painting cels, but if mass-producing several sets for multiple people, painting entire blank cels was an option, but cel costs add up, so usually we used "blank spaces" on cels rejected for some reason. Mouth cels and eye cels were all blank spaces, so they were GOOD.

Once dry, to prevent strips from sticking when stacked, we'd paste thin white paper on the backs of painted strips. We'd also write paint numbers on that paper. Then use office hole punchers to "bash!" one hole and thread them on rings - complete.

As a precaution, when painting strips, if you don't properly note what paint number you painted near the painted colour, similar colours are numerous and you'll lose track later (laughs).

I loved making these strip charts, and every time rush jobs came in with new paints available, I'd steadily make strip charts. It was like a collection. Maybe I was a kind of maniac (laughs). And besides the main STAC colours I used daily, I worked especially hard making strip charts of **Taiyo Shikisai** paints.

There was a proper reason for this - it was absolutely necessary for the "STAC-Taiyo Shikisai paint conversion" I mentioned before. Without paint colour samples,

dealing just with paint numbers was often incomprehensible. Moreover, Taiyo Shikisai paints had complex numbering systems with fine detail and many numbers. So for better, closer colour conversion, these were essential.

This would prove very helpful later when I did colour direction for many theatrical works at Toei Doga.

So, using the strip charts made this way, we colour directors from the cel paint era would wear them out.

When thinking about and specifying some colour - like the colour of props a character holds - first you envision what kind of colour to use, then use the strip chart at hand to combine colours and materialise the image in your head.

If the normal surface colour is this, then what balance of density should the shadow be? Or what colour tone should the shadow be? - combining colours with strip charts while considering combinations.

When deciding character colours, we'd trace character designs or in-between animation and actually place colours to decide, but even then we'd first layer skin colour with colours we planned to use for clothes using strip charts, check the balance, then start painting.

Also, during meetings, when discussing colour images held by directors and us, we could share images with strip charts like "with combinations like this..."

This was an era when we couldn't manipulate nearly infinite colours with digital colouring or create subtle colours and hues exactly as imagined. How to express with limited colours? For this, everyone used their heads to think, imagine, and devise, and strip charts were indispensable important tools.

Colour design and colour direction... or rather, the foundation of finishing begins with "learning colours, learning paints." Especially in "colour specification" work, you can't do the job without properly understanding paint numbers and their colour characteristics and differences. So by painting ourselves this way, we learnt paints and colours.

This remains true in the current digital colouring era. Though tangible things like strip charts no longer exist, whether for character samples or anything else, imagining colours yourself and actually painting them to think things through is a fundamental principle for us in colour design and colour direction.

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